American Red Cross

Disaster Action Team On-Scene Assessment

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools
Respond / Disaster Action Team

Purpose

This job tool provides Disaster Action Team (DAT) Responders with the sequence of steps to take when performing an on-scene assessment.

Audience

- DAT Responders deployed "on scene"
- DAT Duty Officers supporting on-scene DAT Responders

On-Scene Assessment

Upon arrival, the DAT Responders conduct the on-scene assessment led by the DAT Supervisor. Together they gather information and begin analyzing the situation, focusing on what information is needed before client interviews begin. Circumstances on scene may change or evolve over time, so the assessment should be repeated as necessary.

Arrive on Scene

- ☐ Verify all Red Cross responders are present, and ensure the DAT Duty Officer knows which responders are on scene.
- ☐ Ensure all responders understand the reporting structure: who their supervisor is and how to contact other team members.
- ☐ The DAT Supervisor leads the response, assigning tasks to the other responders.

Assess Safety

Primary question: Is it safe for the Disaster Action Team to respond? If the scene is not safe or becomes unsafe, leave and make other arrangements to meet the client.

- ☐ Weather safety: Monitor the weather for active watches, warnings or risks.
- ☐ Personal safety: Are team members clearly identifiable as Red Cross representatives? Does every team member have a partner and necessary supplies, such as a flashlight, phone, and sturdy shoes?
- ☐ Scene safety: Watch for downed powerlines and debris. Do not drive over fire hoses. Park where your vehicle does not disrupt emergency services response. Assess and monitor the mood of the clients and any bystanders. Do DAT Responders feel safe gathering information and conducting interviews?
- ☐ Incident/public safety: Are there any active law enforcement notifications or other safety concerns related to the response area? Do not cross police lines. Follow the direction of the authorities (police/fire/Incident Commander).

Check In with Incident Commander to Obtain Situational Awareness

- ☐ Identify Incident Commander or other on-scene official (typically, the fire department).
- ☐ Explain Red Cross presence and services that may be offered.
- ☐ Clarify the sequence of events and status of current situation:
    - What occurred? Confirm any details provided before arriving on scene.
    - When did the event occur? How long have residents been out of their homes?
    - Where is the affected area? What is the extent and scale of the disaster area?
    - Is the situation escalating, de-escalating, or stable?
    - Are there any immediate needs, like water, restrooms, or a safe meeting location? Are there any disruptions of utilities that impact residents?
    - Who has been affected? Where are the affected residents? How many families, units, or homes have been affected? Are all residents still on scene? If not, where are they now?
    - Were there any injuries or fatalities? Were any clients transported to a hospital or other location?
    - Do the residents have any special needs which may require additional resources? (Examples: Is language an issue? Are children involved? Do residents have access or functional needs? Are there pets?)

Identify Others Present On-Scene

- ☐ Partners: Are any partners present? What is their role? Are other Red Cross resources needed to support coordination?
- ☐ Media: Follow protocol set by the region. Take contact information for follow up and notify the DAT Duty Officer of media on scene.
- ☐ Local Officials: Other than the Incident Commander, are there other agencies or local or elected officials on scene? If so, obtain contact information.
- ☐ Landlord/Manager: Is the landlord or property manager present? If so, obtain contact information and find out if they have plans to support their tenants or limit access to the unit.

Initial Service Delivery Planning and Resource Assessment

- ☐ Estimate the number of cases to be opened by considering the number of affected housing units and identified families. Refer to Casework and Recovery Planning Toolkit for resources such as *Casework Resident List Job Tool* and *Casework Event Strategy Checklist*.
- ☐ Do you anticipate the need to request or open a shelter? Is the landlord able to house everyone affected in vacant units?
- ☐ What resources are required to conduct client interviews and open cases?
    - Human: Multi-family fires may require additional team support:
        - How many responders are needed to open cases?
        - Does a portion of your team need to go to a secondary location (i.e., hospital) to meet with clients that are no longer on site?
        - Do all responders have casework training and permissions in CAS 2.0 to perform tasks?

        - Are responders able to stay as needed or is a second shift required?
        - Are additional responders needed to do livability assessments?
    - Facility: Is there a safe, private, and comfortable location to conduct client interviews?
    - Supplies:
        - Do responders have enough client assistance cards to support the number of cases expected?
        - Do responders have devices to do entry into CAS 2.0 on scene?
        - Does team have intake worksheets and forms required to conduct all client interviews?
        - Do responders have emergency supplies on hand to distribute to clients (blankets, water, toys, and comfort kits)?

- ☐ Are any additional services needed on scene – canteen services, Disaster Health Services, Disaster Mental Health, Disaster Spiritual Care? Communicate additional needs to the DAT https://intranet.redcross.org/content/redcross/categories/our_services/disaster-cycle-services/core-and-pillar-processes/respond/DAT-toolkit.htmlDuty Officer.
- ☐ Is there a way to connect with any clients who are not present on scene?

Response Escalation Triggers and Initial Incident Report

- ☐ Have any of the triggers for an Initial Incident Report (IIR) been met? A report is triggered when:
    - A death has occurred.
    - Multiple significant injuries have occurred.
    - A Red Cross employee or volunteer staff member is injured.
    - A Red Cross facility is damaged.
    - A significant evacuation occurs in a community.
    - A shelter is, or will be, opened or put on standby.
    - The incident has significant media coverage.
    - The estimated cost is expected to exceed $10,000.
    - Mutual aid is expected to occur or is occurring. (Mutual aid occurs when Red Cross human/material resources are requested from outside of the affected region.)
    - A state, local, tribal, or territorial Emergency Operations Center and/or a FEMA Regional Response Coordination Center has been activated and the Red Cross is providing coverage.

If any of the above response escalation triggers are present (meaning the answer is "yes" to any of the above questions), contact the DAT Duty Officer as soon as soon as possible. The DAT Duty Officer determines whether to escalate to the Regional Leadership On Call. The Initial Incident Report (IIR) is submitted per the region's protocol.